importantly, how, when and where it was to be conducted. This definitely reflected poorly on such higher commanders. Besides, such actions lowered the confidence of the junior leaders and tended to confuse the rank and file too. We must remember it is these junior leaders who would actually conduct the manoeuvres, and also lead their men in battle.

On getting back I held a conference of my team. It was my first encounter with my staff and advisers posted at the corps headquarters.

'When was the corps exercised last, and are there any documents or after-action reports available?' I demanded. Since no one had any answer, I realized that we would have to start from scratch. Hence, I directed everyone present, as well as all others concerned, to get on with the preparations for Exercise Poorna Vijay on a war footing.

Having prepared my subordinates mentally, the next challenge was to field the tanks, armoured fighting vehicles, guns and other combat weapons platforms for the exercise. The equipment-intensive Strike Corps is like an Anaconda and the slumber from which it had to be woken up also meant making up the deficiencies and bringing the obsolete or off-road equipment back in shape. Considering the time constraints, this was no mean task. But thanks to the Kargil conflict, the Army HQ was more receptive to our requests and we were able to receive most of the equipment, though some of this happened because of my previous posting as ADGMO. My staff worked out the approximate cost of our inventory of tanks, guns, missiles, transport and equipment, and it came to a whopping 25,000 crore rupees!

Exercises in the desert of Rajasthan were generally conducted during the winter period to avoid the hot summer, when the temperatures could shoot up to 50 degrees Celsius. This time we wanted to test man and machine in the scorching heat.

For any professional military leader, there is no greater joy or satisfaction than to take his command out for a manoeuvre and rehearse his assigned tasks or mission. For me it would be a great learning experience to conduct an exercise of the Strike Corps, with over 50,000 troops taking part in it; an infantry and an armoured